

SEO CASE STUDY

Keyword Research, Step by Step: "SEO Expert" in Focus

A practical, tool-by-tool breakdown of how real keyword research is done — from a free Google search to a full SEMrush-style deep dive.

Focus Keyword

SEO Expert

Methods Covered

3 Tools

Data Type

Live Screenshots

INTRODUCTION

Why This Case Study Exists

Keyword research is often taught as a single-tool exercise — open a tool, type a word, read the volume. In reality, good keyword research is a layered process. Each tool answers a different question. This case study walks through that process using one real target keyword — **"SEO Expert"** — across three different methods: a completely free approach (Google itself), a trend-validation tool (Google Trends), and a professional-grade research platform (a SEMrush-style tool). The goal is to show not just *what* the data says, but *how* to read it.

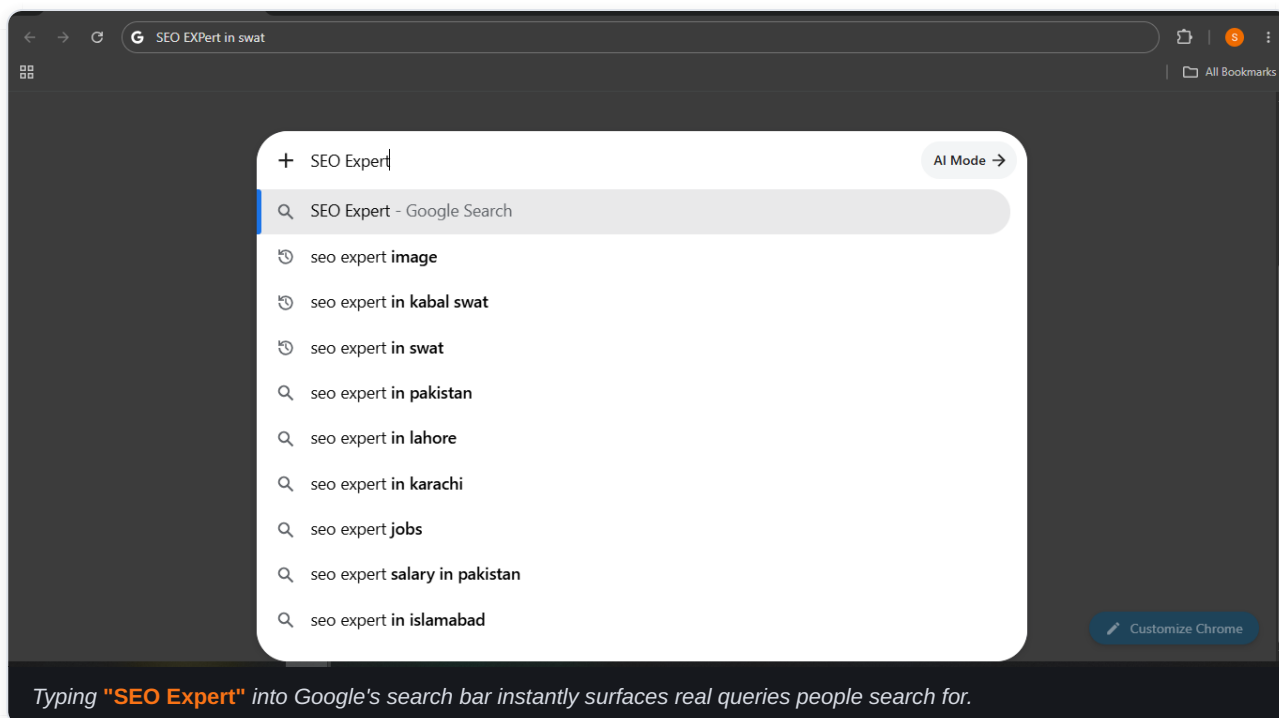
METHOD 1

Google Search Itself

100% FREE

Before opening any paid tool, Google's own search bar is the fastest way to learn how real people phrase their queries. Three features were used here: **Autocomplete**, **People Also Ask**, and **People Also Search For**.

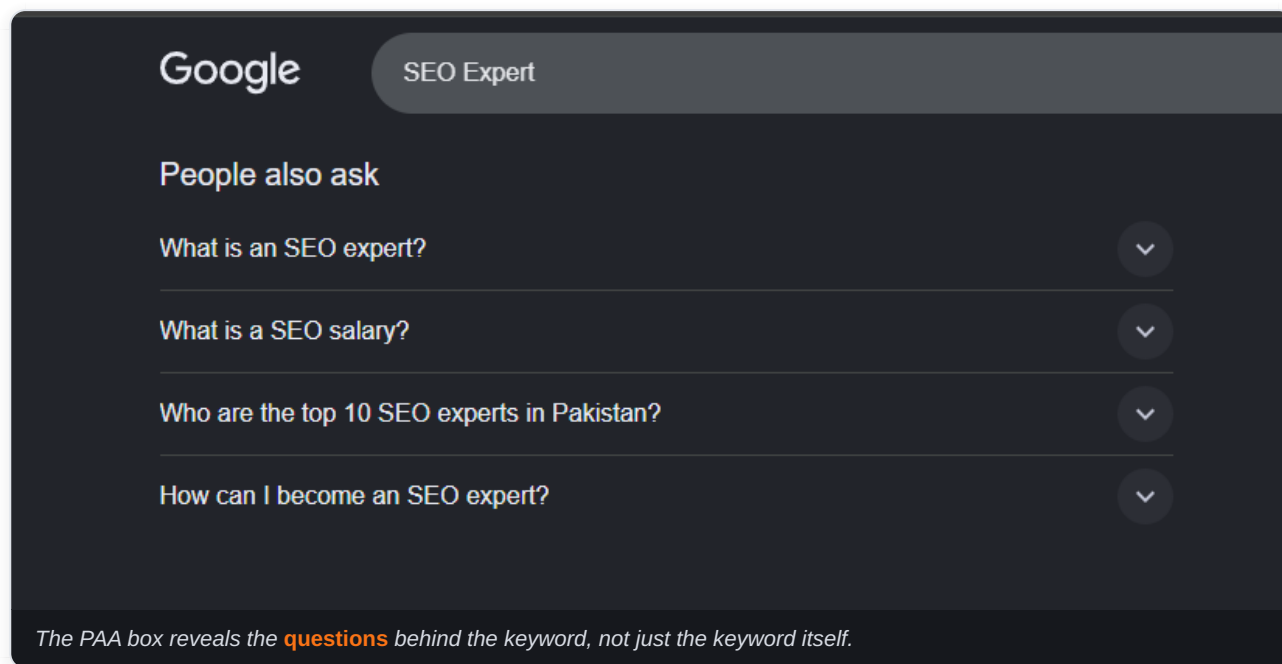
1.1 — Autocomplete Suggestions



The moment "SEO Expert" is typed, Google suggests city-based variations on its own: *seo expert in kabal swat*, *seo expert in swat*, *seo expert in pakistan*, *seo expert in lahore*, *seo expert in karachi* — alongside informational queries like *seo expert jobs* and *seo expert salary in pakistan*.

Insight: The pattern "SEO expert in [city]" is common enough that Google surfaces it before a full sentence is even typed — including a hyper-local variant, "Kabal Swat," a town within Swat itself.

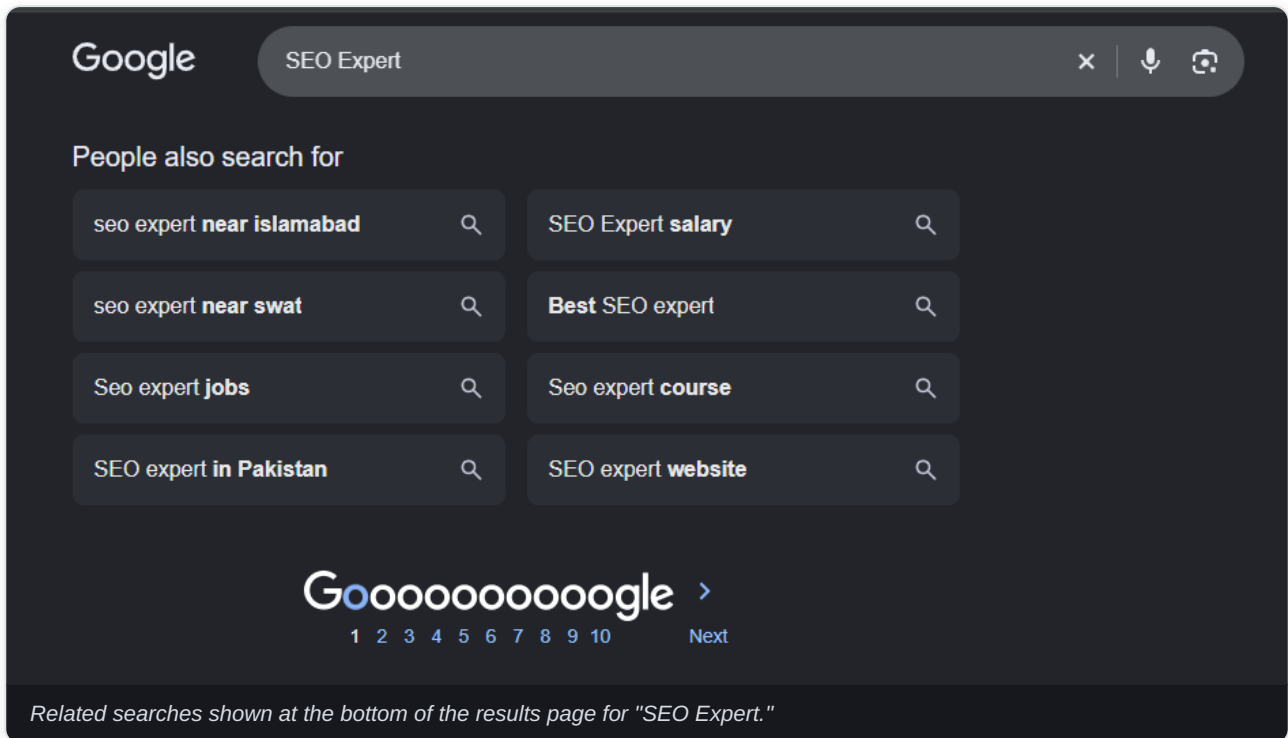
1.2 — People Also Ask (PAA)



Searching "SEO Expert" directly surfaces four recurring questions: *What is an SEO expert?* *What is a SEO salary?* *Who are the top 10 SEO experts in Pakistan?* *How can I become an SEO expert?*

Insight: These are **informational** queries — asked by people learning about the role, not hiring for it. They're excellent blog topic ideas, but shouldn't be confused with commercial, hire-me keywords.

1.3 — People Also Search For



This box confirmed the local-intent pattern directly: *seo expert near islamabad*, *seo expert near swat*, *best seo expert*, *seo expert course*, *seo expert website*.

Insight: Google itself suggested "**seo expert near swat**" — validating that this is a real, city-specific search pattern worth targeting, not just an assumption.

Method 1 Takeaway

Google's free, built-in features reveal two distinct search intents for the same core keyword:

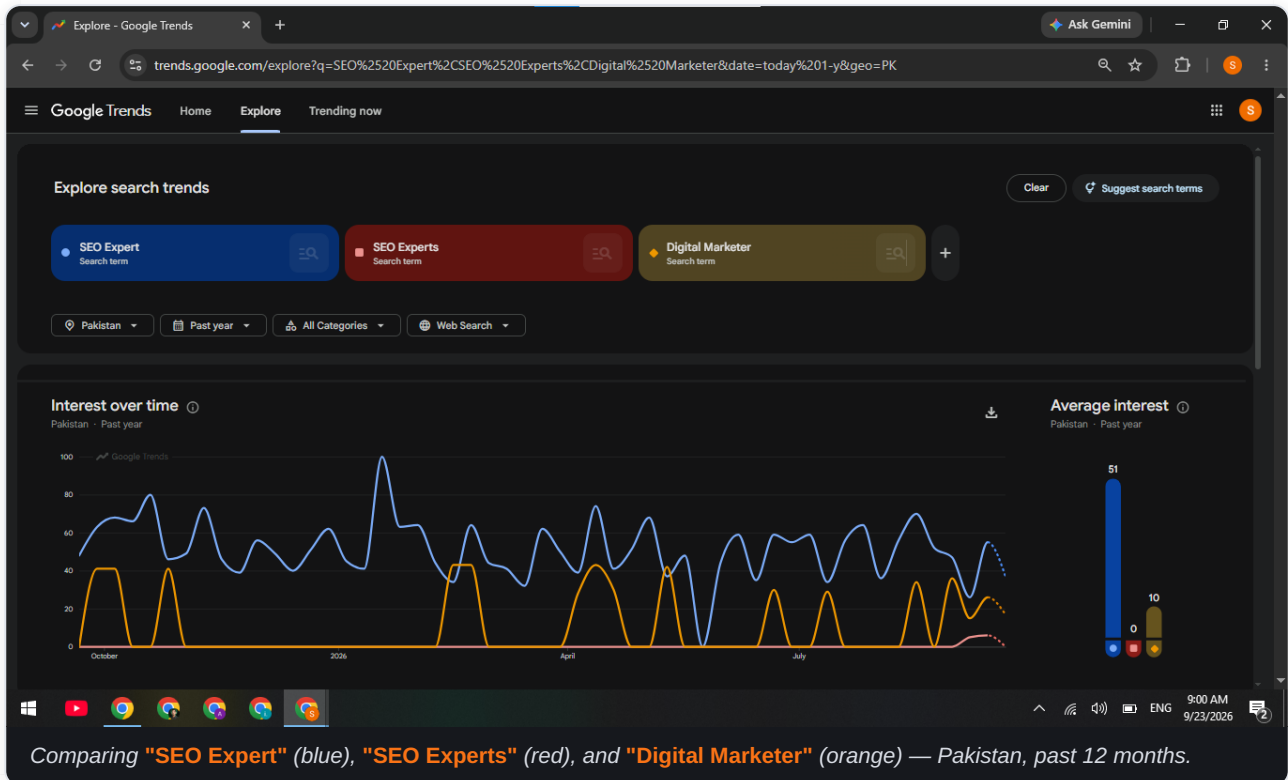
- **Hire intent:** "near me," "in [city]," "best," which convert into clients
- **Learn intent:** "course," "salary," "how to become," useful for blog/content topics, not landing pages

METHOD 2

Google Trends

100% FREE

Volume numbers alone don't tell you whether a keyword is *rising*, *seasonal*, or *already dying out*. Google Trends fills that gap by comparing search interest over time.



51

SEO EXPERT (AVG)

0

SEO EXPERTS (AVG)

10

DIGITAL MARKETER (AVG)

The singular form **"SEO Expert"** stayed consistently ahead all year, with visible spikes around October, April, and July. The plural form, **"SEO Experts,"** barely registered any search interest at all — a small but important detail.

Insight: A tool's raw volume number is not the full picture. Word **form matters** — singular vs. plural can be the difference between a keyword that works and one that's essentially dead. Always test both.

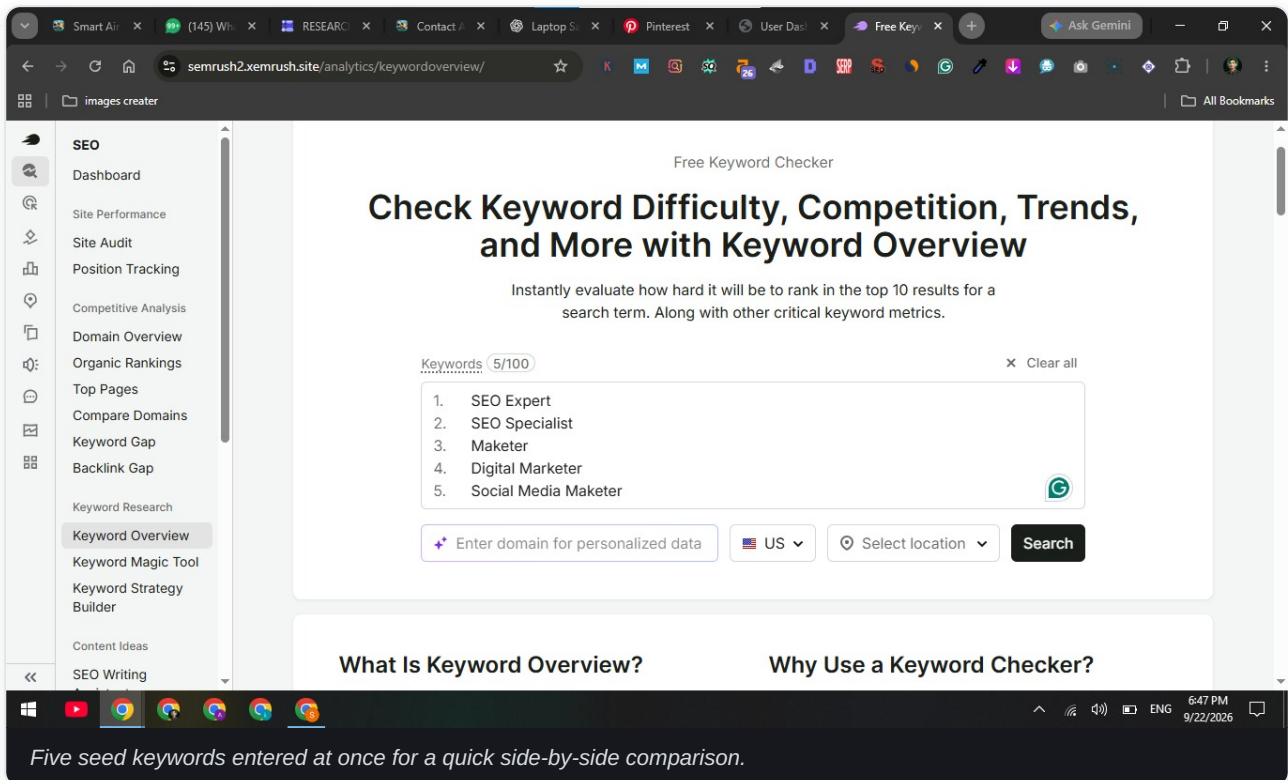
METHOD 3

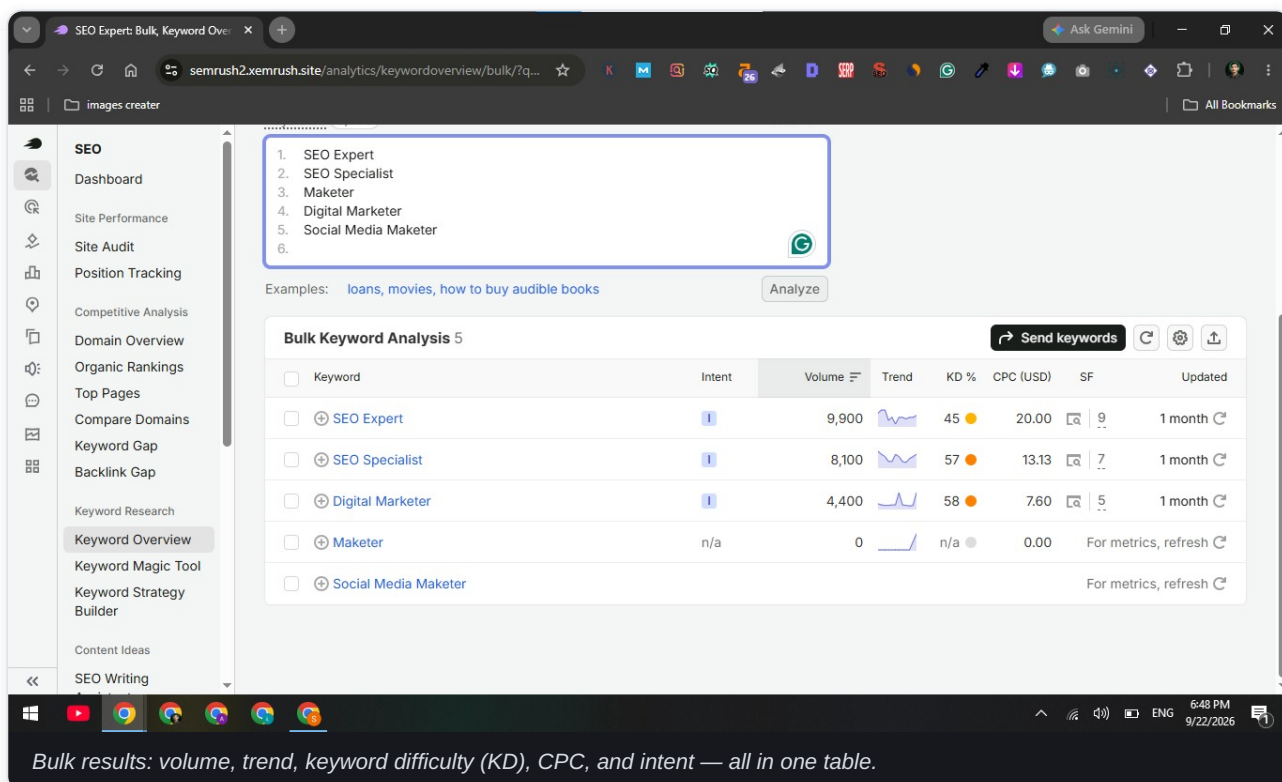
Keyword Research Platform

PAID / PRO TOOL

Once free tools confirm the direction, a full-featured keyword research platform (SEMrush-style) is used to go deep — pulling exact search volumes, difficulty scores, related keywords, and competitor rankings in one place.

3.1 — Starting Point: Bulk Keyword Analysis





1. SEO Expert
2. SEO Specialist
3. Maketer
4. Digital Marketer
5. Social Media Maketer
6.

Examples: [loans](#), [movies](#), [how to buy audible books](#) Analyze

Bulk Keyword Analysis 5 Send keywords

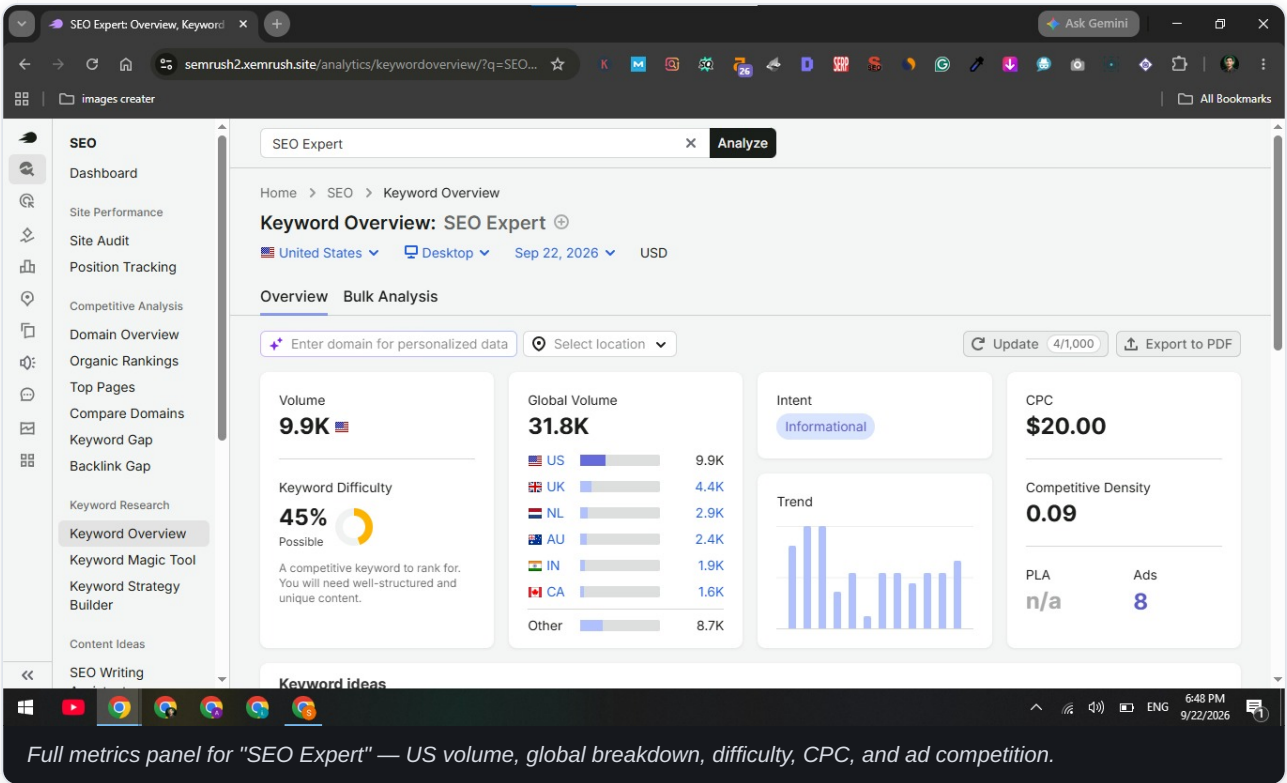
Keyword	Intent	Volume	Trend	KD %	CPC (USD)	SF	Updated
☐ SEO Expert	I	9,900		45	20.00	9	1 month
☐ SEO Specialist	I	8,100		57	13.13	7	1 month
☐ Digital Marketer	I	4,400		58	7.60	5	1 month
☐ Maketer	n/a	0		n/a	0.00		For metrics, refresh
☐ Social Media Maketer							For metrics, refresh

Bulk results: volume, trend, keyword difficulty (KD), CPC, and intent — all in one table.

Keyword	Volume	KD%	CPC (USD)	Intent
SEO Expert	9,900	45	\$20.00	Informational
SEO Specialist	8,100	57	\$13.13	Informational
Digital Marketer	4,400	58	\$7.60	Informational
Maketer (typo)	0	n/a	\$0.00	—
Social Media Maketer (typo)	0	n/a	—	—

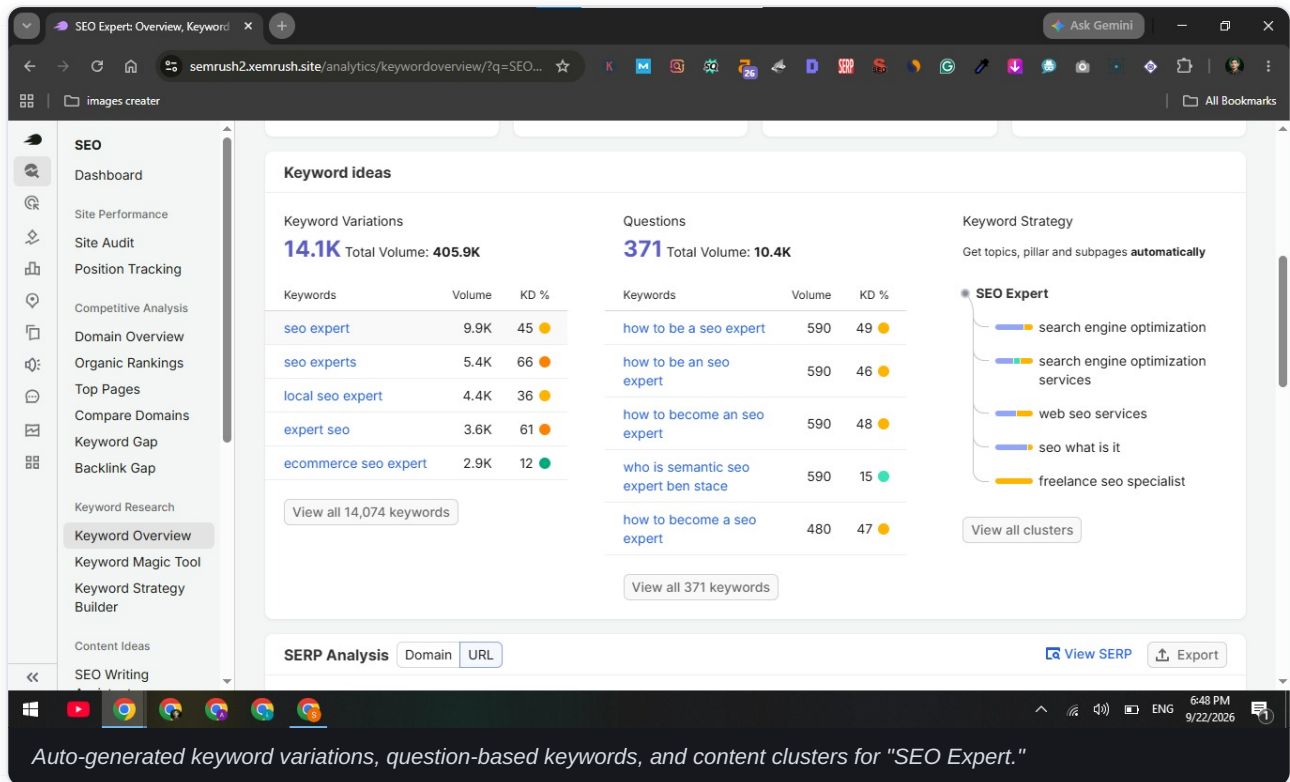
Insight: Two of the five keywords returned **zero volume** — both were spelling mistakes ("Maketer" instead of "Marketer"). Tools match exact spelling; always double-check for typos before concluding a keyword has no demand.

3.2 — Keyword Overview: Going Deep on "SEO Expert"



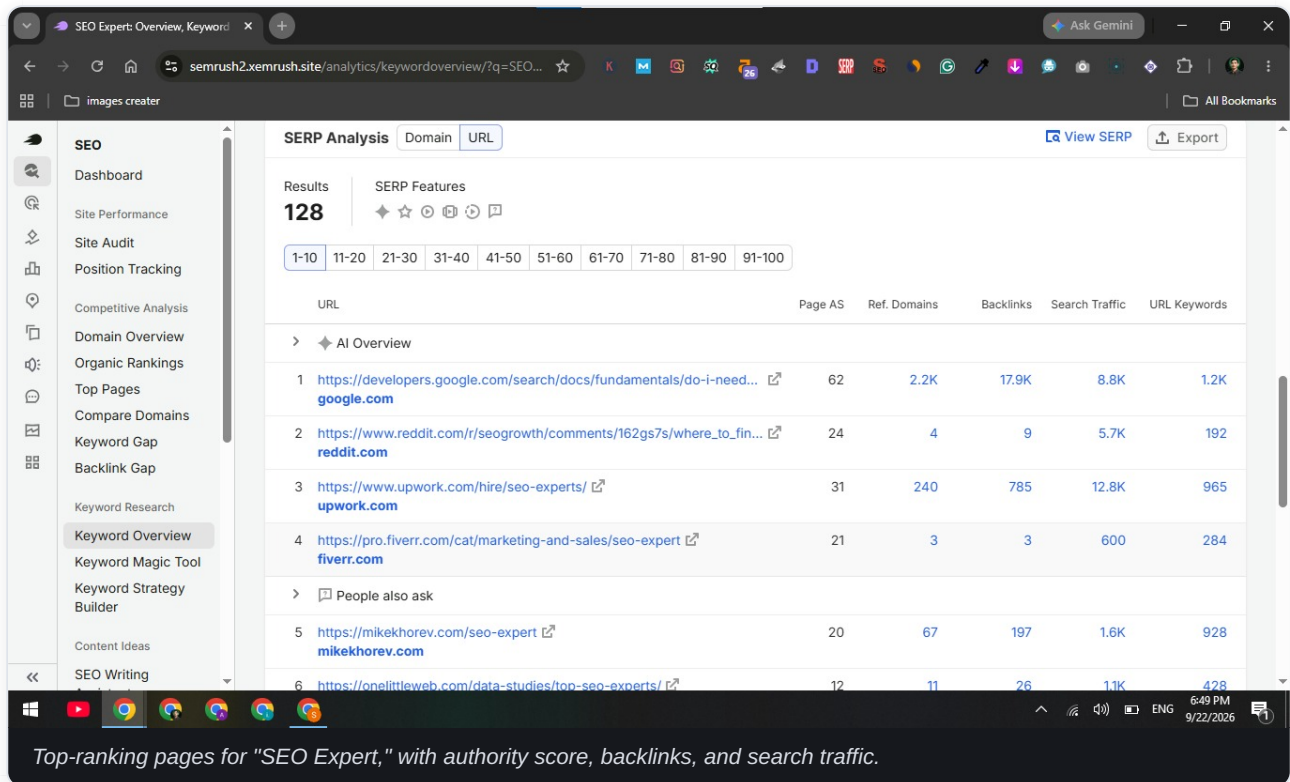
The global breakdown showed 31.8K total searches across countries — led by the US (9.9K), UK (4.4K), Netherlands (2.9K), Australia (2.4K), and India (1.9K). An \$20 CPC with 8 active advertisers confirms this keyword has real commercial value, even though it's classed as "informational" intent.

3.3 — Keyword Ideas: Variations, Questions & Strategy Clusters



The tool also auto-suggested a content cluster strategy branching from "SEO Expert" into topics like *search engine optimization*, *seo services*, *web seo services*, and *freelance seo specialist* — a ready-made content plan for a full SEO service page.

3.4 — SERP Analysis: Who's Actually Ranking



The top 5 results were a mix of **freelance marketplaces** (Upwork, Fiverr) and **individual expert/blog sites** — with Google's own developer documentation ranking #1 due to its massive authority (2.2K referring domains, 17.9K backlinks).

Insight: A mixed SERP (marketplaces + personal brands) means there's room for a well-optimized individual or agency page to compete — the space isn't dominated by one type of website.

3.5 — Keyword Magic Tool: Expanding the Universe

SEO Expert: Keyword Magic Tool

semrush2.xemrush.site/analytics/keywordmagic/?q=SEO+E...

SEO

Dashboard

Site Performance

Site Audit

Position Tracking

Competitive Analysis

Domain Overview

Organic Rankings

Top Pages

Compare Domains

Keyword Gap

Backlink Gap

Keyword Research

Keyword Overview

Keyword Magic Tool

Keyword Strategy Builder

Content Ideas

SEO Writing

Enter domain for personalized data

Volume KD % Intent CPC (USD) Include keywords Exclude keywords Advanced filters

Topics **new** Groups

Sort by **keywords**

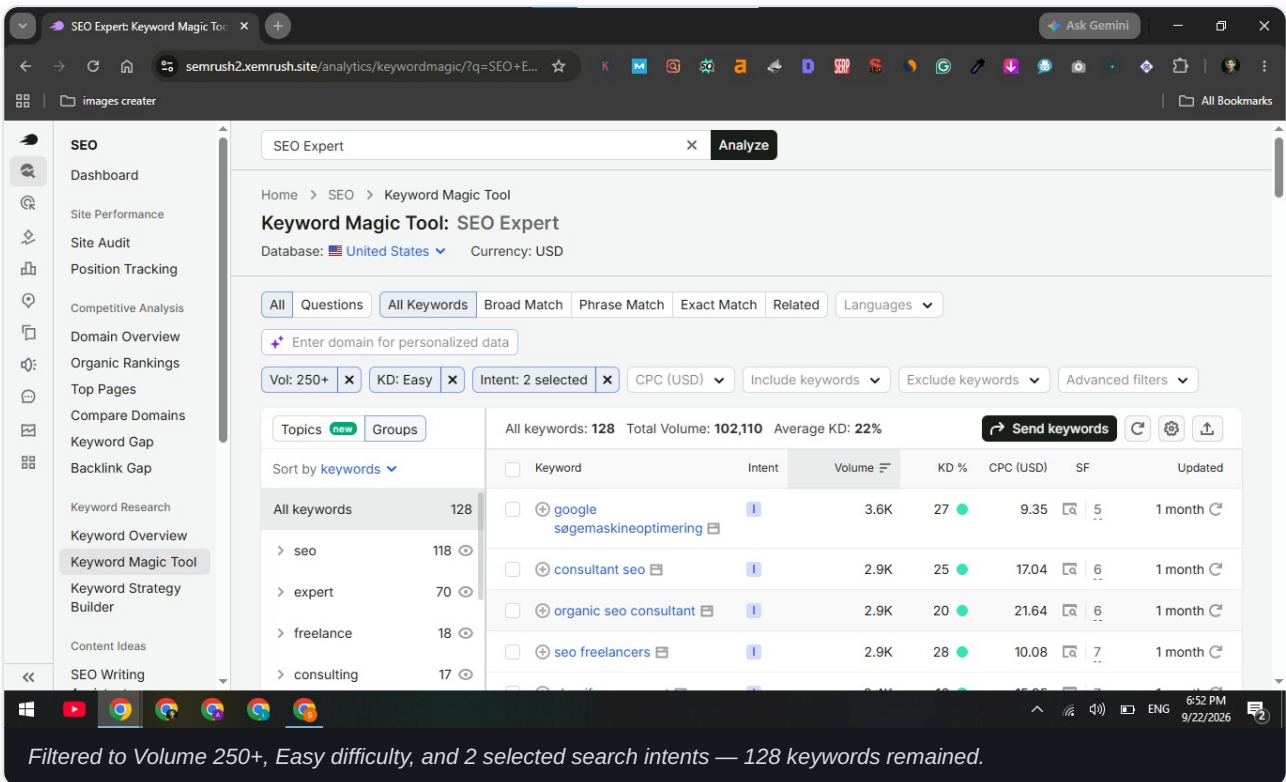
All keywords: 15.1K Total Volume: 782,330 Average KD: 27% Send keywords

Keyword	Intent	Volume	KD %	CPC (USD)	SF	Updated
seo consultant	I	18.1K	56	17.04	7	1 month
seo consulting	I	9.9K	49	17.04	8	1 month
seo expert	I	9.9K	45	20.00	9	1 month
seo specialist	I	8.1K	57	13.13	7	1 month
best seo professionals	C	6.6K	55	21.79	8	1 month
best+seo+professionals	C	5.4K	56	21.79	9	1 month
search optimization consultant	I	5.4K	46	17.04	9	1 month
seo experts	C	5.4K	66	20.00	9	1 month
local seo expert	C	4.4K	36	15.00	7	1 month

15,149 related keywords surfaced from one seed term, grouped by topic (seo, expert, local, best, top...).

This single seed term expanded into **15,149 related keywords** with a combined volume of **782,330** and an average difficulty of just 27%. Surprisingly, **"seo consultant"** outranked the original seed keyword in volume — 18,100 vs. 9,900 for "seo expert."

3.6 — Filtering for Realistic, Rankable Opportunities



Keyword	Volume	KD%	Intent
consultant seo	2,900	25	Informational
organic seo consultant	2,900	20	Informational
seo freelancers	2,900	28	Informational

Insight: Filtering is where research becomes **strategy**. Instead of chasing the highest-volume keyword ("seo consultant," KD 56), filtering surfaced easier, lower-competition alternatives with solid volume — a faster path to ranking.

COMPARISON

Which Method Should You Use, and When?

Method	Cost	Best For	Limitation
Google Search	Free	Real user phrasing, quick validation, content ideas	No volume numbers, no difficulty score
Google Trends	Free		

		Confirming demand direction, comparing keyword forms	Relative interest only, not exact volume
SEMrush-style Tool	Paid	Exact volume, difficulty, CPC, competitor SERP data	Requires subscription for full data access

SUMMARY

Key Takeaways From This Case Study

- 1 Start free, then go deep.** Google Search and Trends validate direction before spending time in a paid tool.
- 2 Separate hire-intent from learn-intent keywords.** "Near me" and "in [city]" convert; "course" and "salary" educate.
- 3 Check word form.** Singular vs. plural, or a single typo, can completely change a keyword's volume.
- 4 Look past the seed keyword.** Related terms like "seo consultant" sometimes outperform the original target.
- 5 Filter for realistic wins.** The highest-volume keyword isn't always the best one to target — difficulty and intent matter just as much.

The Bigger Picture

Keyword research isn't about picking one "best" tool — it's about layering free validation with deep, data-backed analysis. This process, applied to "SEO Expert," can be repeated for any niche or location-based keyword.